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SOON, AS THE MOST POWERFUL POLITICIAN ON EARTH, OBAMA WILL HAVE TO MAKE HARD CHOICES AT HOME AND BEYOND.

the rise of anti-Americanism in the mean streets of the Middle East and elsewhere. Today, the panegyrists of Obamaism are already singing the virtues of the transcontinental virtues of the next President's middle name: Hussein. Imagine what the name can achieve in, say, Baghdad or Karachi or Kandahar—so goes the wonderment. Maybe a lot in irony. Does the Obama version of “the renewal of American leadership” mean the formal end of American idealism—the same idealism that freed Iraq from the tyranny of

another Hussein? He wants to bring the American troops home within 16 months of his presidency. Does it mean he is abandoning Iraq midway? For him Iraq is the wrong war; Afghanistan is the real thing: “We must refocus our efforts on Afghanistan and Pakistan—the central front in our war against Al Qaeda—so that we are confronting terrorists where their roots run deeper.” And to put Osama bin Laden out of business, he will go to any extent. The option includes unilateral military action within Pakistan. On

Iran and North Korea too, he will not “take the military option off the table”, but the first option will be dialogue. The much derided American Imperium will be on AWOL.

For the moment let America romance its audacious choice. When he was a young boy, Obama's mother bought him a book called *Origins*, “a collection of creation tales from around the world, stories of Genesis and the tree where man was born, Prometheus and the gift of fire, the tortoise of Hindu legend that floated in space, supporting the weight of the world on its back.” Later, the fables would come back to him as brain-racking questions. “What supported the tortoise? Why did an omnipotent God let a snake cause such grief? Why didn't my father return?” he would ask. At that age, he was “satisfied to leave these distant mysteries intact, each story self-contained and as true as the next, to be carried off into peaceful dreams.” The boy has come a long way, carrying with him so many dreams. The saddest part is he can no longer afford to leave distant mysteries, ranging from Mesopotamia to the Hindu Kush, intact.

The multiplying mysteries of this world will be a harsh test for someone with less than five years of experience in national politics. Maybe this perceived inexperience will be his biggest advantage. After all, he is going to be the leader of a country that continues to celebrate individual mythologies, oversized dreams, and the idealism of the boldest. On the 4th of November, America changed itself to make the dream of Barack Hussein Obama a historic reality. It is for the man who promises to bring an end to Washington's politics-as-usual to live up to the expectation of a nation where hope is no longer a four-letter word. He cannot take his place in the bar menus for granted. ■

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